When Yu died, his son Qi took the throne and continued the Xia dynasty. This series of appointed rulers continued until Jie of the Xia Dynasty (1600 BC) came to power and oppressed the people. It is generally accepted that he was ruthless to the people and only cared for his own pleasures. When Tang of the Shang kingdom heard about this, he gathered his men and attacked Jie. Jie's army was defeated after a long and brutal battle known as the Battle of Mingtiao. The people had mixed feelings because they did not have to bow down to an oppressive ruler like Jie anymore. Yet there was a new ruler from a different tribe who was foreign to many of them. Tang promised the people he would be a just ruler and founded the Shang Dynasty.

The Shang Dynasty lasted between 1,600 – 1,046 BCE. Tang originated from the Shang kingdom and is generally accepted to have lived between 1,675 and 1,646 BCE. However, the events that occurred during this time do not match with the events ascribed to him. What we do know is that Tang was either the king or an extremely significant figure from the Shang kingdom. During his reign, he lowered the taxes, abolished the expensive construction projects that were initiated by Jie and ruled wisely overall. The country made great strides in art formation by creating various sculptures and literary works. The earliest writing system was established during the Shang Dynasty.

Before the Shang Dynasty, the Chinese people used to worship a variety of deities including the highest god Shangti. This is similar to the gods of the Ancient Greeks where Zeus is at the head of the pantheon. Shangti was believed to be the Great Ancestor of the people and the patron god of agriculture. Believers looked towards Shangti to guide them through strife and hard times. Nonetheless, since Shangti was so far removed from the people, the Chinese required something else that would be more accessible than a distant god. This dilemma led to ancestor worship because the Chinese began to believe that the deceased person was granted divine abilities.

This caused many of the living to call upon their ancestors in times of need. The idea further developed into a series of complex religious ceremonies